

YOUNGJUN LEE, PH.D.

CONTACT INFORMATION

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Technology-Based Physical Activity Interventions (e.g., Immersive Virtual Reality, Mobile Health Applications), Mental Health in Developmental Disabilities, Population-Level Health Data Analysis, Wearable-Derived Health Metrics

EDUCATION

- 2025 **Michigan State University (Ph.D.)** Michigan, United States
Department of Kinesiology, Physical Activity in Youth Disabilities Lab
Dissertation: "Immersive Virtual Reality Exercise to Improve Depressive Symptoms in Young Adults with Autism Spectrum Disorder"
Advisor: Dr. Janet Hauck
- 2022 **Korea University (M.S.)** Seoul, Korea
Department of Physical Education, Exercise Nutrition Biochemistry Lab
Dissertation: "Effect of Physical Activity and Nutritional Behavioral Change on Metabolic Syndrome in Overweight Young Women of Single-person Households"
- 2020 **Korea University (B.Ed.)** Seoul, Korea
Department of Physical Education

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Postdoctoral Research Fellow, Children's Hospital of Philadelphia 2026 – Present
Department of Pediatrics, Division of Gastroenterology, Hepatology and Nutrition

REFEREED JOURNAL PUBLICATIONS

- Published
- [P1] **Lee Y***, Guidotti F, Capranica L, Pesce C, Benzing V, Hauck J, Ciaccioni S. Olympic combat sports and mental health in children and adolescents with disability: A systematic review of controlled trials. *Frontiers in Psychology*. 2025;16:1567978. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2025.1567978>
- [P2] **Lee Y***, Capranica L, Pesce C, Guidotti F, Benzing V, Hauck J, Ciaccioni S. Olympic combat sports and mental health in children and adolescents with disability: A protocol paper for systematic review. *PLoS ONE*. 2025;20(2):e0301949. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0301949>
- [P3] Sung E*, **Lee Y***, Lee S, Park J. (*co-first authors) Analysis of sleep duration, energy intakes, physical activity, and metabolic syndrome based on the presence or absence of obesity and hypertension in working Korean adults. *Frontiers in Public Health*. 2025;13:1588706. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2025.1588706>
- [P4] Ciaccioni S, **Lee Y**, Guidotti F, Stankovic N, Pococco E, Izzicupo P, Capranica L. Combat sports and wellbeing: Advancing health and inclusion in athletes and practitioners. *Frontiers in Psychology*. 2025;16:1587672. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2025.1587672>
- [P5] Kim Y, Kim E, **Lee Y**, Park J. The role of late eating in circadian disruption and depression: A review of emotional health impacts. *Physical Activity and Nutrition*. 2025;29(1):18-24. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.20463/pan.2025.0003>
- [P6] **Lee Y***, Kim N, Go S, Kim J, Park J. Sugary snack restriction enhances body composition improvement in overweight women engaging in non-face-to-face walking during COVID-19. *Frontiers in Public Health*. 2024;12:1396598. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2024.1396598>
- [P7] **Lee Y***, Hauck J, Brooks D. Sex-specific physical activity levels and energy intake in US young adults with depression: National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey 2017–2020 pre-pandemic data. *Physical Activity and*

Health. 2023;7(1):332-344. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.5334/paah.305>

- [P8] **Lee Y***, Park Y, Lee J, Sung E, Lee H, Park J. Household-specific physical activity levels and energy intakes according to the presence of metabolic syndrome in Korean young adults: Korean National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey 2016–2018. *BMC Public Health*. 2022;22:476. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.21203/rs.3.rs-923728/v1>
- [P9] Sung E, Lee S, **Lee Y**, Lee S, Park J. Analysis of energy intakes, physical activities and metabolic syndrome according to the income level in Korean elderly people: Korean National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey 2016–2018. *Physical Activity and Nutrition*. 2022;26(2):28-35. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.20463/pan.2022.0011>
- [P10] Park Y, Lee J, **Lee Y**, Park J. Comparative analysis of energy intake and physical activity according to household type and presence of metabolic syndrome in middle-aged men based on data from the 7th Korea National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey (KNHANES) (2016–2018). *Physical Activity and Nutrition*. 2021;25(4):1-9. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.20463/pan.2021.0020>

* denotes first author

Under Review

- [R1] **Lee Y**. Socioeconomic adversity and adverse childhood experiences as predominant predictors of mental health in autistic children: The limited protective role of physical activity. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*.
- [R2] **Lee Y**, Vazou S, Kim S, Ratan R, Hauck J. Effect of a 4-week virtual reality boxing exercise program on depression and heart rate variability in autistic young adults: A pilot randomized controlled trial. *Adapted Physical Activity Quarterly*.
- [R3] **Lee Y**, Vazou S, Kim S, Hauck J. Effects of a 6-week virtual reality boxing exercise on depressive symptoms and heart rate variability in young adults: A pilot randomized controlled trial. *Mental Health and Physical Activity*.
- [R4] **Lee Y**, Vazou S, Kim S, Ratan R, Hauck J. Interest in immersive virtual reality boxing exercise among college students with and without autism spectrum disorder. *Disability and Rehabilitation: Assistive Technology*.
- [R5] Brooks D, **Lee Y**, Bullard L, Hauck J, Vazou S. Contextual factors, barriers, and facilitators when implementing school-based physical activity interventions for youth with disabilities: A scoping review. *Mental Health and Physical Activity*.
- [R6] Go S, **Lee Y**, Kim N, Kim H, Park J. Non-face-to-face intervention of sugar restriction management further improved body composition in overweight and obese men engaging in brisk walking: A randomized controlled trial. *Nutrition Research and Practice*.
- [R7] **Lee Y**, Vazou S, Kim S, Ratan R, Kim N, Kim Y, Hauck J. A systematic review of immersive VR exergames for individuals with developmental disabilities. *Disability and Rehabilitation: Assistive Technology*.
- [R8] **Lee Y**, Brooks D, Kim S, Hauck J. Organized sports and psychosocial benefits for adolescents with autism: Findings from the 2022 national survey in a pandemic recovery context. *European Journal of Adapted Physical Activity*.
- [R9] **Lee Y**, Chun H, Kim N, Stubbs B. Nonlinear association between sedentary time and depression in the post-COVID-19 United States: Evidence from NHANES 2021–2023. *Mental Health and Physical Activity*.
- [R10] **Lee Y**, Ciaccioni S, Stodden D, Hauck J, Lima R, Pesce C. Physical activity and adolescent mental health across 45 countries: The moderating role of country-level perceived health. *Mental Health and Physical Activity*.
- [R11] Ciaccioni S, **Lee Y**, Capranica L, Guidotti F, Massini S, May R, Pozdnyakova Y, & OPES Italia. Building resilience and equity: A synthesis of evidence for crisis management in grassroots sport. *Societies*.
- [R12] **Lee Y**, Kim N, Lee B, Chae J, Park J. School-level differences in the pathway

from physical activity to suicidal ideation via anxiety among Korean adolescents. *Journal of School Health*.

PRESENTATIONS

Published Abstracts

- [A1] Lee J, **Lee Y**, Lin P, Luo T, Bonner S (June 2025, Poster). MoodMiles: A gamified exercise application for mental and physical well-being in young adults with all abilities. *Human-Computer Interaction International, Gothenburg, Sweden*.
- [A2] **Lee Y**, Ratan R, Vazou S, Kim S, Kim Y, Hauck J (June 2025, Poster). Exploring the effects of immersive virtual reality exercise on depressive symptoms, heart rate variability, and motivation for physical activity in young adults. *NASPSPA, Lake Tahoe, United States*.
- [A3] Brooks D, **Lee Y**, Bullard L, Hauck J, Vazou S (June 2025, Poster). Exploring contextual influences on school-based physical activity programs for youth with disabilities: A scoping review. *NASPSPA, Lake Tahoe, United States*.
- [A4] **Lee Y**, Capranica L, Pesce C, Guidotti F, Benzing V, Hauck J, Ciaccioni S (June 2024, Poster). Exploring the impact of Olympic combat sports on mental health of young individuals with disabilities: A meta-review protocol with preliminary insights. *NASPSPA, Louisiana, United States*.
- [A5] **Lee Y**, Brooks D, Hauck J (June 2023, Poster). Physical activity and energy intake in US young adults with depression: National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey 2017–2020 pre pandemic. *NASPSPA, Toronto, Canada*.

Conference Presentations

- [C1] Brooks B, **Lee Y**, Hauck J, Fisher M, West P (Feb 2026, Poster). Health and the role of employment among young adults with intellectual and developmental disabilities: Scoping review. *MSU College of Nursing Research Day, Michigan, United States*.
- [C2] Brooks B, **Lee Y**, Hauck J, Fisher M, West P (Jan 2026, Poster). Health and the role of employment among young adults with intellectual and developmental disabilities: Scoping review. *DADD, California, United States*.
- [C3] **Lee Y**, Kim S (July 2025, Poster). Synergizing physical activity and organized sports: Enhancing psychosocial well-being in adolescents with ASD in post-pandemic. *World Congress of Sociology of Sport, Seoul, Korea*.
- [C4] Kim S, **Lee Y**, Park S (July 2025, Poster). How team sports shape health in youth with autism: Examining the mediating effects of flourishing and socialization. *World Congress of Sociology of Sport, Seoul, Korea*.
- [C5] Brooks D, Hauck J, **Lee Y** (Sep 2024, Oral). Exploring physical activity experiences in children with autism spectrum disorder. *NAFAPA, New York, United States*.
- [C6] **Lee Y**, Brooks D, Hauck J (Sep 2024, Oral). Assessing the impact of an immersive virtual reality exercise on depression and anxiety in young adults with ASD. *NAFAPA, New York, United States*.
- [C7] Ciaccioni S, **Lee Y**, Hauck J, Capranica L, Guidotti F, Benzing V, Pesce C (July 2024, Oral). Olympic combat sports and mental health in children and adolescents with disability – preliminary results of a systematic review. *ECSS, Glasgow, Scotland*.
- [C8] Anttila E, Brooks D, **Lee Y**, Hauck J (April 2023, Poster). Examining the differences in PA levels between unified partners and Special Olympic athletes at the 2022 Special Olympics Unified Cup Soccer. *UURAF, Michigan, United States*.
- [C9] Go S, **Lee Y**, Kim N, Park J (Aug 2022, Oral). The effects of non-face-to-face intervention of brisk walking and sugar restriction on body weight, physical fitness and insulin sensitivity in overweight and obese men. *KAHPERD, Gyeonggi-do, Korea*.

- [C10] **Lee Y**, Kim N, Go S, Park J (Mar 2022, Oral). Effect of non-contact brisk walking and sugar intake restriction on body fat and osteocalcin (OC) in young women during the COVID-19 outbreak period. *KSSO, Seoul, Korea*.
- [C11] **Lee Y**, Kim N, Go S, Park J (Oct 2021, Oral). Effect of non-contact brisk walking and sugar intake restriction on body fat and osteocalcin (OC) in young single-person households during the COVID-19 outbreak period. *KAHPERD, Gumi, Korea*.

RESEARCH GRANTS

External Funding

In Preparation

- NIH K99/R00 Pathway to Independence Award, Role: PI, Expected Submission: June 2026

Submitted

- Lurie Autism Institute Catalyst Pilot Grant, Children's Hospital of Philadelphia (2026), Role: Co-Investigator

Internal Funding

- KIN Endowed Fellowship, Michigan State University (2025), \$1,500
- Future of Work Graduate Student Funding, Michigan State University (2025), PI, \$3,000
- Summer Research Fellowship, Michigan State University (2025), \$7,000
- Hard Cost Practicum/Dissertation Funding, Michigan State University (2024), PI, \$1,763
- Summer Research Fellowship, Michigan State University (2024), \$7,000
- Summer Research Development Fellowship, Michigan State University (2023), \$7,000
- Summer Research Development Fellowship, Michigan State University (2022), \$6,000

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Graduate Teaching Assistant, Michigan State University 2022 – 2025

- KIN 492 Internship in Kinesiology
- KIN 300C Soccer Coaching
- KIN 173 Foundations of Kinesiology
- KIN 121 The Healthy Lifestyle
- KIN 116B Golf
- KIN 108R Indoor Soccer
- KIN 107E Tennis
- KIN 103T Distance Running
- KIN 103G Power Walking
- KIN 103D General Conditioning
- KIN 103A Aerobic Exercise

TEACHING GRANTS

- Inclusive Teaching Grant, Michigan State University (2025), \$1,400

SCHOLARSHIP AWARDS

- David Cho Scholarship Award, Michigan State University (2025), \$1,000
- Dr. Kenneth Hardin Graduate Student Endowed Scholarship, Michigan State University (2025), \$1,500
- Henry J. and Betty Montoye Endowed Scholarship Award, Michigan State University (2024), \$2,325

TRAVEL AWARDS

- Travel Fund, Department of Kinesiology, Michigan State University (2024), \$600
- COGS Conference Award, Michigan State University (2024), \$300
- Travel Fund, Department of Kinesiology, Michigan State University (2024), \$400
- Travel Fund, Graduate School, Michigan State University (2023), \$600
- Travel Fund, Department of Kinesiology, Michigan State University (2023),

\$400

MENTORSHIP ACTIVITIES

Mentored Undergraduate Students in Journal Club

Ronnie Aniel, Anela Panlasigue, Sathvik Suryadevara, Emma Anttila, Monique Karoub, Elaine Nevins, Brooke Johnson, Chloe Barnes, Rylee Bernhauser, Landon Moreno, Bronwen Smith, Christopher Stubbe, Laura Whitney, Maryann Hermiz, Alaina Barringer, Sarah Segarra, Lydia Miller, Morgan Adelini

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

- North American Federation of Adapted Physical Activity (2024 – Present)
- North American Society for the Psychology of Sport and Physical Activity (2023 – Present)
- Korean Society Exercise Nutrition (2021 – Present)
- Korean Alliance for Health, Physical Education, Recreation, and Dance (2021 – Present)

SERVICE ACTIVITIES

Scholarly and Professional Organizations

- Student Ambassador, NASPSPA, Toronto, Canada (2023)

Reviewing for Journals

- Frontiers in Psychology (2026 – Present)
- Journal of Applied Research in Intellectual Disabilities (2025 – Present)
- Mental Health and Physical Activity (2025 – Present)
- BMJ Open (2025 – Present)
- Applied Psychology: Health and Well-Being (2025 – Present)
- Frontiers in Psychiatry (2025 – Present)
- Journal of Physical Activity and Health (2024 – Present)
- Journal for Advancing Sport Psychology In Research (2024 – Present)

Military Service

- Ulleungdo & Dokdo Security Unit, Gyeongbuk, Korea (2016 – 2017), Mandatory Service as a Police Officer
- WKAR Public Media (October 21, 2025). *From the ring to the MSU classroom: How VR technology is helping with autism spectrum disorder.*

[Link](#)

MEDIA & PRESS COVERAGE

SKILLS

- Proficient in statistical analysis using R and SPSS
- Experienced in biological and physiological assessments, including blood biomarker analysis (e.g., glucose, insulin, osteocalcin) and heart rate variability (e.g., RMSSD, SDNN, LF/HF ratio)
- Skilled in designing and implementing immersive virtual reality-based interventions using Meta Quest
- Experienced in conducting systematic and scoping reviews aligned with PRISMA guidelines
- Expertise in analyzing large-scale national health datasets (e.g., NHANES, NSCH, KNHANES)

Last Updated: March 2026